MIGRATORY POLITICIANS

Prominent Karnataka legislators who have changed parties so far



A.T. RAMASWAMY
JD(S) to BJP

JAGADISH SHETTAR
BJP to Congress





M.P. KUMARASWAMY
BJP to JD(S)



BABURAO CHINCHANSUR
BJP to Congress

K.M. SHIVALINGE GOWDA
JD(S) to Congress





PUTTANNA
BJP to Congress



LAXMAN SAVADI
BJP to Congress



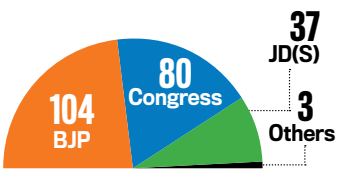
N.Y. GOPALAKRISHNA
BJP to Congress



S.R. SRINIVAS
JD(S) to Congress

THE SCENARIO IN 2018

TOTAL SEATS: 224



of Dakshina Kannada, Uttara Kannada and Udupi, all of which are BJP bastions, it managed to replace as many as six candidates without facing any significant hassle. What came as a complete shock was Shettar and Laxman Savadi, a member of the Legislative Council and a former deputy CM, quitting the party to join the Congress.

The Congress, too, had been facing dissidence of its own when just the previous week, it announced tickets to as many as five legislators who had recently hopped from the BJP and the Janata Dal (Secular). However, it had also kept several seats open, significantly Hubli-Dharwad Central and Athani, where Shettar and Savadi, respectively, have been named as candidates now. The likely effect of this realignment, political observers say, will play out in the north-western belt of 'Kittur Karnataka' in which the BJP and Congress square off against each other in a straight fight. This region—formerly known as Bombay-Karnataka—stretching from Belagavi district on the Maharashtra border down to Haveri, has been another BJP stronghold for several years, given the sizeable Veerashaiva-Lingayat population in these parts. In the 2018 election, it won 30 out of the 50 seats here.

"Shettar's entry will strengthen us in north Karnataka," said AICC president Mallikarjuna Kharge who was in Bengaluru on April 17 for the former's induction into the party. Shettar, 67, has won elections from Hubli-Dharwad Central consecutively since 1994, and hails from a family whose Jan Sangh roots go back two generations. "Why did they sideline a person with this background?" he kept asking, pointing out that he was the seniormost Lingayat leader in the BJP after B.S. Yediyurappa. Instead of being allowed to bow out gracefully, Shettar said he was hurt by the party's decision to inform him at the last minute, over the phone, that he will not be getting a party ticket.

While Shettar's exit from the BJP was sudden, Savadi's ties with the party had been souring since 2019 when the BJP came to power in Karnataka with the help of 17 defectors. Among these was former Congressman Mahesh Kumathalli, who had defeated Savadi at Athani by 2,331 votes in 2018. In the bypolls that followed, Kumathalli won back his seat as the BJP's candidate while Savadi was appointed deputy CM and, in February 2020, elected as an MLC. This time, both aspired to the Athani seat but Belagavi political heavyweight Ramesh Jarkiholi managed to secure the ticket for Kumathalli. It was Jarkiholi who had led the batch of defectors to the BJP in 2019. Political observers say the latest tussle for tickets reflects his growing clout in the district.

All this also makes Belagavi—the second-largest district after Bengaluru with 18 assembly